

The Equation of a Hyperplane

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Where this fits: Pipeline map step 0 (Foundations). See the [Course map](#).



- **Builds on:** Dot product ([Note MA-050](#)).
- **Leads to:** Perceptron ([Note DL-004](#)); Perceptron trick ([Note DL-005](#)).

1. Overview

Key point: One equation, $w^T x + w_0 = 0$, describes a line in 2D, a plane in 3D and a hyperplane in any number of dimensions; w is perpendicular to it and w_0 moves it away from the origin.

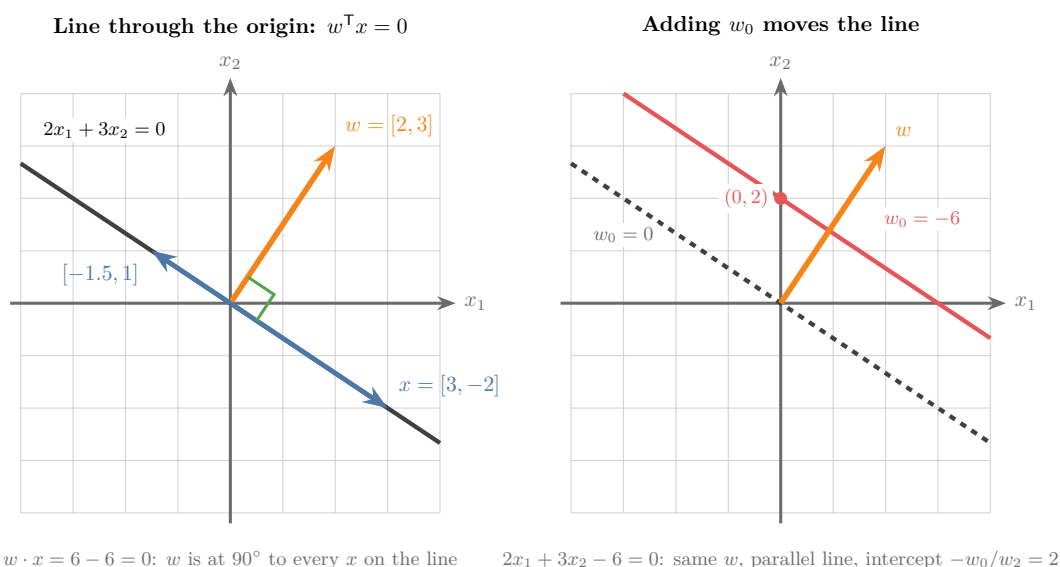


Figure 1: Left: a line through the origin and the vector w perpendicular to it. Right: adding w_0 moves the line without turning it

Figure 1 shows the whole result in 2D. On the left, every vector x on the line makes a right angle with w , so $w \cdot x = 0$. On the right, adding a number w_0 slides the line to a parallel position. This Note builds that equation step by step from the school equation of a line, and then reads off what w and w_0 mean.

The Note uses the dot product and its geometric form from the [dot product and cosine similarity Note](#).

2. Why ML needs hyperplanes

Key point: A line in 2D becomes a plane in 3D and a hyperplane beyond; models that classify with a straight boundary need its equation in any dimension.

In 2D a flat boundary is a line; in 3D it is a plane. In 4D, 5D or n -D the equivalent is a **hyperplane** (G-911; see the [multiple linear regression Note](#)).

ML data is very often high-dimensional. Each **feature** (G-772; an input variable, one column of the data table) adds one dimension. Even the iris toy dataset has 4 features, and MNIST, the handwritten digits dataset, has 784 (one per pixel of a 28 x 28 image). Classifiers that separate classes with a straight boundary, such as [logistic regression](#) and [SVM](#), therefore work with hyperplanes. To use them, and to code such algorithms ourselves, we need one equation that works in every dimension.

Figure 2 shows one such boundary on real data. With three features of the iris flowers (sepal length, petal length and petal width), a linear SVM fitted with scikit-learn finds a **plane** (G-1502) with every setosa flower on one side and every versicolor flower on the other. With all four features the same boundary would be a hyperplane, which we can no longer draw but can still write down.

A plane in 3D: $-0.54x_1 + 0.98x_2 + 0.62x_3 - 0.18 = 0$

• setosa
• versicolor

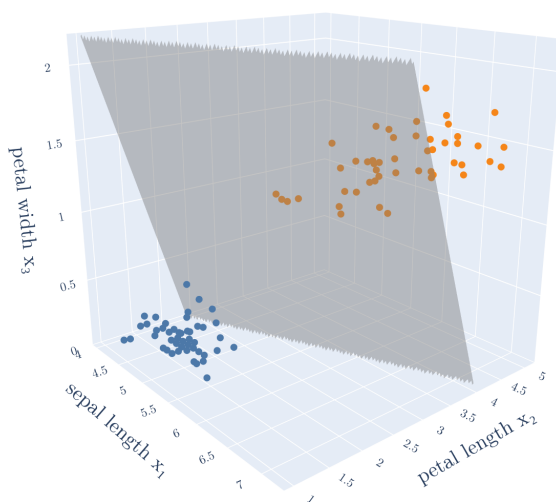


Figure 2: Iris setosa (blue) and versicolor (orange) in three features, separated by the plane $-0.54x_1 + 0.98x_2 + 0.62x_3 - 0.18 = 0$ that a linear SVM (scikit-learn LinearSVC) found.

3. From a line to a hyperplane

Key point: Rename the general form of a line as $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_0 = 0$; each extra dimension adds one more term w_ix_i .

3.1 The general form of a line

Key point: $y = mx + b$ and $ax + by + c = 0$ describe the same line; the general form is the one that grows into higher dimensions.

In school a line is $y = mx + b$, with **slope** (G-1823) m and **intercept** (G-960) b . The same line has a general form, $ax + by + c = 0$, used in the [perceptron trick Note](#) (section 3.1).

Solving the general form for y links the two:

$$y = -\frac{a}{b}x - \frac{c}{b}, \quad \text{so} \quad m = -\frac{a}{b}, \quad \text{intercept} = -\frac{c}{b}$$

(the b of the general form is a different number from the intercept b of $y = mx + b$). We use the general form, because it treats every axis the same way.

3.2 Renaming for n dimensions

Key point: Call the axes $x_1, x_2, \dots$ and the coefficients $w_1, w_2, \dots$, with w_0 for the constant.

Letters x, y, z run out after three dimensions, so we number the axes instead: $x_1, x_2, x_3, \dots$. We number the coefficients the same way, $w_1, w_2, \dots$, and call the constant term w_0 . Then:

- **Line (2D):** $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_0 = 0$
- **Plane (3D):** $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_3x_3 + w_0 = 0$
- **Hyperplane (n -D):** $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + \dots + w_nx_n + w_0 = 0$

Each new dimension adds one term. With numbers, the line $2x + 3y - 6 = 0$ becomes $2x_1 + 3x_2 - 6 = 0$: here $w_1 = 2$, $w_2 = 3$ and $w_0 = -6$. Figure 3 (left) draws it in the school form: slope $-a/b = -2/3$ and intercept $-c/b = 2$. The right panel plugs points into the equation, which section 4 writes as a dot product.

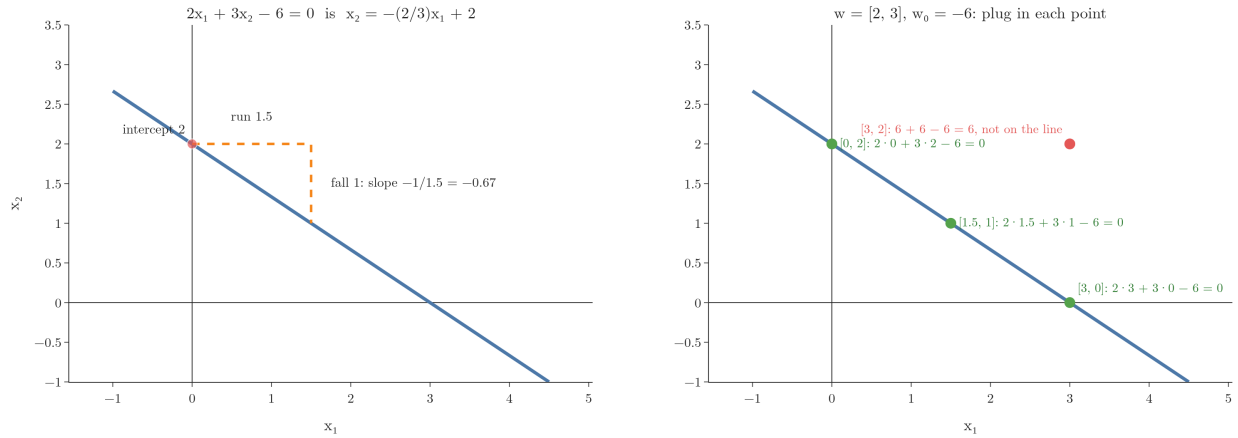


Figure 3: The line $2x_1 + 3x_2 - 6 = 0$. Left: the same line as $x_2 = -(2/3)x_1 + 2$, with its slope triangle and intercept 2. Right: $[3, 0]$, $[0, 2]$ and $[1.5, 1]$ give 0 and lie on the line; $[3, 2]$ gives 6 and does not.

4. The vector form

Key point: The sum $w_1x_1 + \dots + w_nx_n$ is a dot product, so the hyperplane is $w \cdot x + w_0 = 0$, or $w^\top x + w_0 = 0$.

Look at the part $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + \dots + w_nx_n$. This sum multiplies matching components and adds them, which is exactly a dot product. Collect the coefficients into one vector and the coordinates into another:

$$w = \begin{bmatrix} w_1 \\ w_2 \\ \vdots \\ w_n \end{bmatrix}, \quad x = \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{bmatrix}$$

Both are column vectors, the default. Writing the dot product as a row times a column, $w \cdot x = w^\top x$, gives the equation of a hyperplane:

1. **In words:** the dot product of the coefficient vector with any point on the hyperplane, plus the constant, is zero.
2. **Formula:**

$$w^\top x + w_0 = 0$$

3. **Example:** for $w = [2, 3]$ and $w_0 = -6$, the point $x = [3, 0]$ gives

$$w^\top x + w_0 = 2 \times 3 + 3 \times 0 - 6 = 0$$

so $[3, 0]$ lies on the line $2x_1 + 3x_2 - 6 = 0$ (Figure 3, right).

This one equation is valid in 2D, 3D and n -D: only the number of components of w and x changes. The equation is the same $w \cdot u + b$ that SVM uses in the [SVM maths Note](#), with $b = w_0$.

5. What w_0 means

Key point: w_0 shifts the hyperplane away from the origin; $w_0 = 0$ exactly when the hyperplane passes through the origin.

To see what w_0 does, go back to 2D, where the line is both $x_2 = mx_1 + b$ and $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_0 = 0$. Section 3.1 matched the intercepts:

$$b = -\frac{w_0}{w_2}$$

Now slide the line down until it passes through the origin. Its intercept b becomes 0, and since $w_2 \neq 0$, that forces $w_0 = 0$. So:

- A line, plane or hyperplane passes through the origin exactly when $w_0 = 0$.
- A non-zero w_0 moves it parallel to itself, away from the origin. In Figure 1 (right), $2x_1 + 3x_2 = 0$ passes through the origin, while $2x_1 + 3x_2 - 6 = 0$ crosses the x_2 axis at $-(-6)/3 = 2$.

Figure 4 turns both knobs on real data: the iris setosa and versicolor flowers, plotted by petal length x_1 and petal width x_2 (in cm). Watch the line while w_0 changes: it slides without turning, and the arrow w keeps its direction. Turning w instead tilts the line, which stays at 90° to w (Section 6). The shaded side is where $w^\top x + w_0 > 0$, the side w points to (the sign rule at the end of Section 6). With $w = [1, 1]$ and $w_0 = -3.2$, all 50 versicolor flowers fall on the shaded side and all 50 setosa flowers on the other.

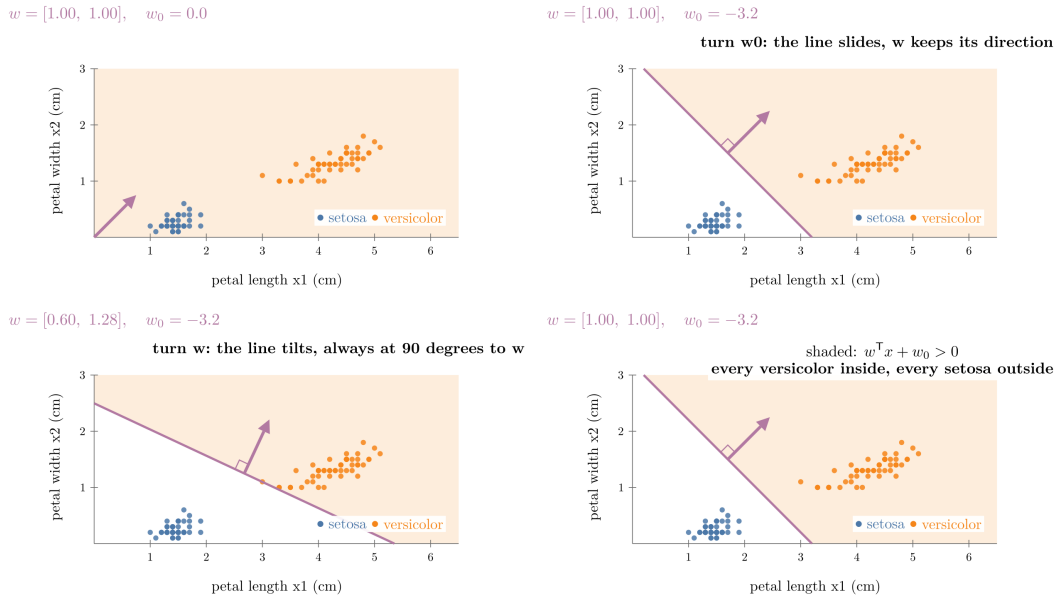


Figure 4: The two knobs of $w^\top x + w_0 = 0$ on iris setosa (blue) and versicolor (orange): changing w_0 slides the line, turning w tilts it; the shaded side is where $w^\top x + w_0 > 0$

So we often take the simplifying assumption that the hyperplane passes through the origin.

The equation then shrinks to

$$w^T x = 0$$

In 2D that is $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 = 0$; in 4D, $w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_3x_3 + w_4x_4 = 0$.

Extra: The assumption costs nothing, because of a standard trick. Add a constant component $x_0 = 1$ to every point, so $x = [1, x_1, \dots, x_n]$, and put w_0 into $w = [w_0, w_1, \dots, w_n]$. Then $w^T x = w_0 + w_1x_1 + \dots + w_nx_n$, and the equation $w^T x = 0$ already contains the shift. The constant component $x_0 = 1$ is the column of ones in the matrix form of the [multiple linear regression maths Note](#).

6. What w means: the normal vector

Key point: $w^T x = 0$ says w makes a 90° angle with every point x on the hyperplane, so w is perpendicular to the hyperplane.

6.1 The argument

Key point: A dot product of non-zero vectors is 0 only at 90° .

For a hyperplane through the origin, every point x on it satisfies $w^T x = 0$. Write the dot product in its geometric form:

$$w^T x = w \cdot x = \|w\| \|x\| \cos \theta = 0$$

For non-zero w and x , the lengths are positive, so $\cos \theta = 0$ and $\theta = 90^\circ$. Each point x on the hyperplane is a vector lying in the hyperplane, and w is at a right angle to every one of them. So w is perpendicular to the hyperplane itself. A vector perpendicular to a line, plane or hyperplane is called its **normal vector** (G-1346).

With numbers, for the line $2x_1 + 3x_2 = 0$ in Figure 1 (left): $w = [2, 3]$, and the points $[3, -2]$ and $[-1.5, 1]$ lie on the line. Both give $w \cdot x = 0$:

$$2 \times 3 + 3 \times (-2) = 0, \quad 2 \times (-1.5) + 3 \times 1 = 0$$

6.2 The same in 3D

Key point: The coefficients of a plane's equation, read as a vector, stick straight out of the plane.

The plane $x_1 + 2x_2 + 2x_3 = 0$ and its normal vector w

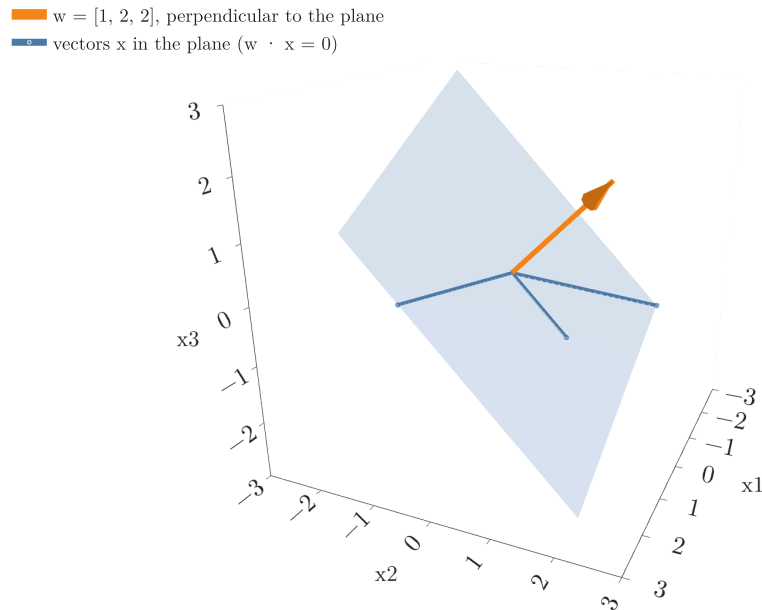


Figure 5: The plane $x_1 + 2x_2 + 2x_3 = 0$ and its normal vector $w = [1, 2, 2]$

Figure 5 shows the plane $x_1 + 2x_2 + 2x_3 = 0$. Its coefficients form $w = [1, 2, 2]$, drawn in orange. The three blue vectors lie in the plane, for example $[2, -1, 0]$, with $1 \times 2 + 2 \times (-1) + 2 \times 0 = 0$. The orange w stands at 90° to all of them.

So reading a hyperplane's equation tells us its direction at once: the coefficients are the normal vector. In n -D we cannot draw it, but the argument of Section 6.1 never used the number of dimensions.

Python: Checking that points lie on a hyperplane is one dot product per point.

```
import numpy as np
```

```
w = np.array([1, 2, 2])
X = np.array([[2, -1, 0], [0, 1, -1], [-2, 2, -1]])
# dot product of every row of X with w
X @ w    # array([0, 0, 0]): all on the plane
```

6.3 A plane from a point and a normal vector

Key point: A point x_0 and a normal vector w fix a plane: it holds every x with $w \cdot (x - x_0) = 0$. Expanding gives $w^T x + w_0 = 0$ with $w_0 = -w \cdot x_0$, so w is the normal vector for any w_0 .

Sections 6.1 and 6.2 assumed $w_0 = 0$. The same result holds for a hyperplane anywhere in space, and Figure 6 shows why in four steps.

1. **One point is not enough.** Think of the plane as a sheet of cardboard pinned at one point, $x_0 = (1, 1, 1)$. The sheet can still pivot about the pin, so one point leaves the plane open.
2. **A normal vector fixes the plane.** Choose the direction that must stand at 90° to the sheet, here $w = [1, 2, 2]$. Only one position of the sheet fits.
3. **Arrows inside the plane.** Take any other point x on the plane. The points x_0 and x are vectors from the origin, and they do not lie in the plane. Their difference $x - x_0$ does: it is the arrow from the pin to x , drawn on the cardboard. So w is at 90° to it, and their dot product is 0 (section 6.1).
4. **The constant slides the plane.** Changing w_0 moves the plane along w without turning it.

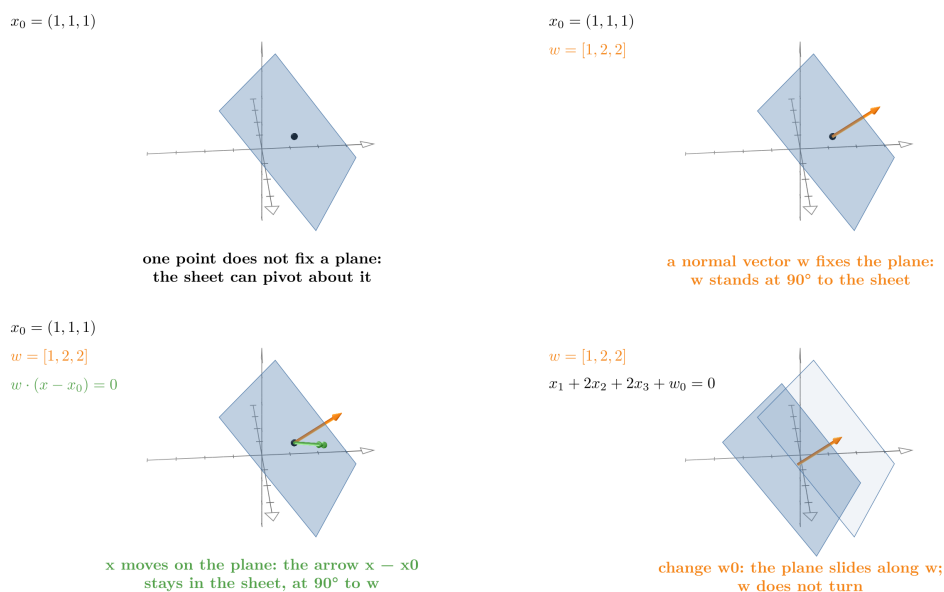


Figure 6: A plane from the point $x_0 = (1, 1, 1)$ and the normal vector $w = [1, 2, 2]$. The sheet can pivot about one point; the normal vector fixes it; the arrow from x_0 to any point x of the plane stays at 90° to w ; changing w_0 slides the plane along w . Idea after Khan Academy, “Defining a plane in $\mathbb{R}^3$ with a point and normal vector”.

Worked example. With $w = [1, 2, 2]$ and $x_0 = (1, 1, 1)$, a point $x = (x_1, x_2, x_3)$ is on the plane when

$$w \cdot (x - x_0) = 1(x_1 - 1) + 2(x_2 - 1) + 2(x_3 - 1) = 0$$

Multiplying out gives $x_1 + 2x_2 + 2x_3 - 5 = 0$. The coefficients are again w , and the constant is $w_0 = -5$. The point $(3, 1, 0)$ lies on this plane, since $3 + 2 + 0 - 5 = 0$.

The formal version. For any number of dimensions,

$$w^\top(x - x_0) = 0 \iff w^\top x + w_0 = 0, \quad w_0 = -w^\top x_0$$

Read from right to left, the same steps show that w stays perpendicular when $w_0 \neq 0$. Take any two points x and y on the hyperplane: $w^\top x + w_0 = 0$ and $w^\top y + w_0 = 0$. Subtracting, $w^\top(x - y) = 0$. The vector $x - y$ runs along the hyperplane, so w is perpendicular to every direction in it.

All hyperplanes with the same w and different w_0 therefore share one normal vector and are parallel. The shared normal vector is why the two lines in Figure 1 (right) are parallel, and why $x_1 + 2x_2 + 2x_3 = 0$ of Figure 5 is parallel to the plane of this example.

Extra: For a point off the hyperplane, $w^\top x + w_0$ is not zero, and its sign says which side the point is on: positive on the side w points to, negative on the other. To see this, start at a point p on the hyperplane and step a distance t along w : $x = p + t w / \|w\|$. Then $w^\top x + w_0 = (w^\top p + w_0) + t w^\top w / \|w\| = 0 + t \|w\|$, which has the sign of t . This sign rule is the side test of the [perceptron trick Note](#) and the decision rule of the [SVM maths Note](#).

7. Summary

Object	Equation	Normal vector
Line (2D)	$w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_0 = 0$	$[w_1, w_2]$
Plane (3D)	$w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + w_3x_3 + w_0 = 0$	$[w_1, w_2, w_3]$
Hyperplane (n -D)	$w^\top x + w_0 = 0$	w
Through the origin	$w^\top x = 0$	w

- The general form of a line grows into a hyperplane by adding one term per dimension; the sum of terms is a dot product.
- w_0 shifts the hyperplane; $w_0 = 0$ means it passes through the origin.
- w is the normal vector: perpendicular to the hyperplane, because $w \cdot x = 0$ means a 90° angle.
- A point x_0 and a normal vector w give the hyperplane $w \cdot (x - x_0) = 0$, so $w_0 = -w \cdot x_0$.

8. Sources

Built from

- CampusX, “Equation of a Hyper-plane in N dimensions”, YouTube, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=b8AgdVA>
- CampusX, “Supercharge Your ML Journey: Mastering Vectors in Linear Algebra - Part 1”, YouTube, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mQewAJb8oJ8>
- Khan Academy, “Defining a plane in R3 with a point and normal vector | Linear Algebra | Khan Academy”, YouTube, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UJxgcVaNTqY>
- Khan Academy, “Normal vector from plane equation | Vectors and spaces | Linear Algebra | Khan Academy”, YouTube, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gw-4wltP5tY>

9. Key terms

Term	Meaning
Equation of a hyperplane	$w^\top x + w_0 = 0$: one equation for a line, plane or hyperplane in any dimension
w_0	The constant term; it shifts the hyperplane away from the origin, and is 0 when the hyperplane passes through the origin
Normal vector	A vector perpendicular to a line, plane or hyperplane; for $w^\top x + w_0 = 0$ it is w